

ANGELS, SKAGGS FAMILY SETTLE AT TRIAL

Earlier efforts to reach an agreement over pitcher’s drug-related death had failed.

By STEVE HENSON

The family of pitcher Tyler Skaggs and the Angels reached a settlement Friday, ending a contentious trial as jurors had begun a third day of deliberations regarding Skaggs’ drug-related death on the road with the team. Terms of the agreement, which followed 31 days of testimony and four years of legal wrangling, were not immediately available.

Jury foreman Richard Chung said after the settlement was announced that the panel had agreed to award Skaggs’ family roughly \$100 million when they were told to cease deliberations — \$60 million to \$80 million for economic damages, \$5 million to \$15 million for emotional distress damages and \$10 million to \$20 million for punitive damages.

Rusty Hardin, the Skaggs family’s lead attorney, told The Times that although he could not reveal the amount of the agreement, “the Skaggs family is extremely happy with the settlement.”

Early efforts to settle the case had been unsuccessful, with the Angels’ legal team and its insurance carriers rebuffing overtures from the lawyers representing Tyler Skaggs’ widow, Carli Skaggs, and his parents, Debbie Hetman and Darrell Skaggs. As recently as Tuesday evening, after the jury had begun deliberations, the lead attorneys from each side met but gained little traction toward a settlement.

The equation changed Wednesday when jurors asked the judge to read back testimony from experts on Skaggs’ future earnings had he lived. The request suggested that the jury had determined the Angels were responsible for at least a percentage of economic damages.

The jury also asked whether it was charged with determining the amount of punitive damages, adding to speculation that it might hand the Skaggs family an award beyond economic and emotional distress damage.

Roughly 95% of civil suits nationwide reach a settlement. [See Skaggs, A7]



GARY CORONADO For The Times

JONATHAN TOVAR, foreground, arranges Christmas trees with Roman Robles.

A Christmas tree tradition that’s lasted generations

How an L.A. immigrant’s grit led to a 76-year-old business

By JEANETTE MARANTOS

It’s mid-November, a full week before Thanksgiving, and the progeny of Francisco Robles, a Mexican immigrant who peddled watermelons in East L.A., have converged in West Covina to commemorate the 76th year of the family’s seasonal business: selling fresh Christmas trees around L.A. from the forests of the Pacific Northwest.

Francisco and his wife, Lucia, left Mexico for a better life in the early 1900s, so it’s hard to imagine what they would make of their thoroughly Americanized descendants today. One of them is looking for a place to plug in her electric car, another is zipping around the large lot on a motorized scooter and a third is carrying [See Robles, A7]



Photo from the Robles family

LOUIS ROBLES SR., right, shown in 1955, supplemented his income by selling Christmas trees.

Even elite graduates are competing with AI for work — and they’re losing

A Stanford software engineering degree used to be a golden ticket. Artificial intelligence has devalued it to bronze, recent graduates say.

The elite students are shocked by the lack of job offers as they finish studies at what is often ranked as the top university in America.

When they were freshmen, ChatGPT hadn’t yet been released upon the world. Today, AI can code better than most humans.

Top tech companies just don’t need as many fresh graduates.

“Stanford computer science graduates are struggling to find entry-level jobs” with the most prominent tech brands, said Jan Liphardt, associate

As chatbots learn to code, entry-level software jobs are vanishing

By Nilesh Christopher

professor of bioengineering at Stanford University. “I think that’s crazy.”

While the rapidly advancing coding capabilities of generative AI have made experienced engineers more productive, they have also hobbled the job prospects of early-career software engineers.

Stanford students describe a suddenly skewed job market, where just a small slice of graduates — those considered “cracked engineers” who already have thick resumes building products and doing research — are getting the few good jobs, leaving everyone else to fight for scraps.

“There’s definitely a very dreary mood on campus,” said a recent com- [See Jobs, A12]

Investors soured by release of fraudster

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — Jeffrey Rosenberg is still trying to understand why President Trump would free the man who defrauded him out of a quarter of a million dollars.

Rosenberg, a retired wholesale produce distributor living in Nevada, has supported Trump since he entered politics, but the president’s decision in November to commute the sentence of former private equity executive David Gentile has left him angry and confused.

“I just feel I’ve been betrayed,” Rosenberg, 68, said. “I don’t know why he would do this, unless there was some sort of gain somewhere, or some favor being called in. I am very disappointed. I kind of put him above this kind of thing.”

Trump’s decision to release Gentile from prison less than two weeks into his seven-year sentence has drawn scrutiny from securities attorneys and a U.S. senator — all of whom say the White House’s explanation for the act of clemency is not adding up. It’s also drawn the ire of his victims.

“I think it is disgusting,” said CarolAnn Tintera, 70, who invested more than \$400,000 with Gentile’s company, GPB Capital. Gentile, she added, “basically pulled a Bernie Madoff and swindled people out of their money, and then he gets to go home to his wife and kids.”

Gentile and his business partner, Jeffry Schneider, were convicted of securities and wire fraud in August 2024 for carrying out what federal prosecutors described as a \$1.6-billion Ponzi scheme to defraud more than 10,000 investors. [See Investors, A6]

E-bikes stoke outcry over safety in South Bay

Residents complain about harassment and gang-like behavior by some youthful riders.

By CLARA HARTER

The surveillance video is tough to watch but impossible to ignore. A group of teens rushes toward a 57-year-old man walking in a dim alleyway near the Hermosa Beach Pier. They surround him, throwing him to the ground and stomping on his head until he loses consciousness.

“He’s dead, he’s dead,” one of them shouts before they jump on their thousand-dollar e-bikes and speed away.

The viral recording of the Nov. 21 incident has become the latest — and most serious — flash point event in the escalating conflict over teen e-bike culture in L.A. County’s South Bay region.

Some beach cities’ residents say the teens’ aggression reflects a broader attitude: that e-bike riders, emboldened by their protected status as minors, increasingly act as if they own the streets.

“They run stop signs, they’re speeding, they’re flipping people off. They’re on their phones or filming themselves for social media,” said Redondo Beach resident Darryl Boyd. “It’s a circus — a psycho circus.”

E-bikes have exploded in popularity across the South Bay over the last five years,

becoming the default way many teenagers travel to school and meet up with friends. The devices have been adopted by teens across the Golden State, leading to a surge in e-bike-related injuries and collisions.

The machines cost anywhere from \$1,000 to \$6,000. Type 1 e-bikes, which are pedal-assisted, and Type 2 e-bikes, which are pedal- and throttle-assisted, can reach up to 20 mph, while Type 3 e-bikes can go up to 28 mph and may only be ridden by those 16 and older in California.

Pocket bikes, electric motorcycles and electric dirt bikes, which are generally not street legal in California, can reach speeds of 45 to 55 [See E-bikes, A9]



GARY CORONADO For The Times

E-BIKES HAVE exploded in popularity in the South Bay, especially among teens, over the last five years.

U.S. carries out strikes in Syria

Hegseth says operation will target Islamic State after the deaths of three U.S. citizens. **WORLD, A4**

Campus shooting suspect is dead

Man is responsible for Brown attack and MIT professor’s slaying, officials say. **NATION, A5**

Tracking down Nick Reiner

Police used geotracking, cellphone data and surveillance to find son of director. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Fog and some sun.
L.A. Basin: 67/51. **B8**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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